putting his arm around my shoulder," says Sanowar Ali, 45, a Congressman from Assam's Barpeta district, showing the prize image sent to him by the yatra's official photo team.

In fact, images are defining the reinvention of Rahul through BJY. If Prime Minister Narendra Modi's images with his mother have become a national spectacle for several years, Rahul sent social media into a tizzy with the photograph of him tying the shoelaces of mother Sonia Gandhi when she came to walk along with him in Karnataka on October 6. If the prime minister strove for the mantle of the nation's fitness guru by championing yoga, 52-year-old Rahul is walking an average 22 km daily at a speed that leaves co-walkers panting—not to speak of the viral videos where Siddaramaiah and D.K. Shivakumar, the former and prospective CMs of Karnataka, were made to sprint. "He walks very fast and doesn't get tired at all even though he sleeps only 4-5 hours at night. I'm yet to see a fitter politician in India," says Randeep Singh Surjewala, Congress general secretary in-charge of Karnataka and Rajya Sabha member.

Rahul doesn't replicate the Modi model. Unlike Modi's colourful attire and well-groomed look, he prefers a dishevelled mien with unkempt hair and a growing salt and pepper beard. The white T-shirt—he is carrying nearly a dozen—has become part of the signature look for the yatra. All the *yatris* wear white T-shirts with the BJY logo and tagline, but Rahul prefers a plain white tee. The differences often vanish, especially during dinner time when he joins the other 122 yatris in the common dining area. There is no camera here and the conversation is free-flowing. "He is so easygoing. He listens to us patiently and answers anything we ask," says 27-year-old Bikash Nath Jogi from Assam. Shamsher Chand, 45, owner of a diagnostic lab in Jammu and Kashmir, concurs.

This is what Team Congress considers the biggest difference between the two leaders, Modi and Rahul. While the PM believes in one-way communication, the Gandhi scion enjoys interacting with people out there. All along the yatra route, he has regularly lent an ear to diverse groups: farmers, teachers, students, women, unorganised workers. "Modi speaks his *mann ki baat*, Rahul listens to people's *mann ki baat*. The yatra is a more direct, intimate way to listen to the voice of India," says Jairam Ramesh, Rajya Sabha member and Congress communications in-charge. And there are many willing to engage with the Congress leader. Take Shaan Ahad, a homemaker from Bengaluru. She's drawn to the peaceful coexistence narrative Rahul is trying to build. That's the reason she travelled to Mysuru—Bengaluru is not on the yatra route—to walk alongside Rahul. "I'm at the receiving end of the hatred spread by the BJP/ RSS. Rahul talks about love and equal treatment for all. It's a simple, powerful message," says Ahad. She is, however, disappointed that the security team didn't allow her closer access; she had to follow from a distance.

Dr Shushruta Hedna, a Mysuru-based neurologist who returned from the US in 2019, was luckier. He is not a Congress worker but was selected as one of the 123 yatris at the recommendation of the Gandhian Rajagopal P.V., founder of Ekta Parishad, a people's movement for land rights. In every state, several such civil society groups will join the yatra. On an average, members of at least 4-5 civil society organisations walk with Rahul every day. "They have not come for any gain. They have joined us because they realise our intent is to save India, as it was envisaged by our Constitution," says Ramesh. Born to

THE PEOPLE BEHIND THE YATRA

CENTRAL PLANNING COMMITTEE


DIGVIJAYA SINGH


SACHIN PILOT


SHASHI THAROOR


RAVNEET SINGH BITTU


K.J. GEORGE


JOTHI MANI


PRADYUT BORDOLOI


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MEMBERS OF TASK FORCE 2024

P. Chidambaram, Mukul Wasnik , Jairam Ramesh, K.C. Venugopal, Ajay Maken, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Randeep Singh Surjewala, Sunil Kanugolu plus heads of all frontal organisations

THE MAN IN CHARGE



K.B. BYJU

Monitors and executes all logistics plans related to the Bharat Jodo Yatra in collaboration with state units